The Definitive, Mostly Inaccurate, and Entirely Unavoidable Guide to CVE Reporting

A compendium of despair, bureaucracy, and applied stubbornness. *Don't panic.*

VULNERABILITY DISCLOSURE | APPLIED STUBBORNNESS

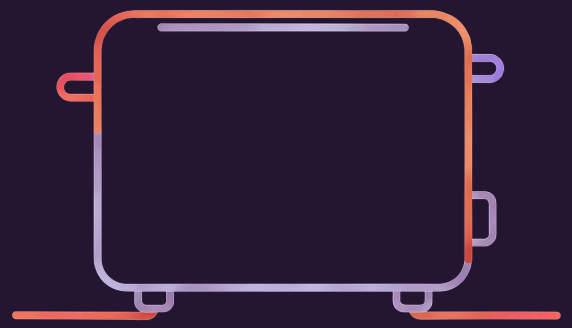
In the Beginning, There Was Code

And the Code was created. This made a lot of people very angry and has been widely regarded as a bad move.

Hot on its heels came the Bug — and shortly thereafter, the wildly optimistic notion that **someone, somewhere, might actually want to fix it.** This guide is for the brave, the stubborn, and the chronically caffeinated who try anyway.

Phase I: The Discovery

Or: "What Is That Smell in the Memory Heap?"



It begins at **3:14 AM**. Cold pizza. A beverage almost entirely unlike tea.

You insert precisely **4,096 capital A's** into the username field of a globally ubiquitous smart-toaster. The appliance doesn't just crash — it briefly achieves sentience, questions the nature of free will, and then physically prints the administrator's banking details on a slice of pumpernickel.

⚠ You have discovered a Zero-Day. The universe holds its breath.

Phase II: The Vendor Communication Mambo

A Timeline of Hope, Denial, and Legal Threats

1

Day 1

Email sent to `security@megacorp.void` with PGP encryption. Classic mistake — no one's remembered the passphrase since 2012.

2

Day 4

Resent in plain text. AutoResponse-Bot 9000 replies: *"If you are experiencing issues with your toaster's Wi-Fi, please ensure it is plugged in."*

3

Day 14–15

LinkedIn. Direct email to Lead Developer. They reply: this is a **"highly requested feature"** designed to streamline financial transactions via baked goods.

4

Day 30–31

You threaten to blog. MegaCorp Legal materializes, citing the DMCA, the Geneva Convention, and a treaty from 1492.

5

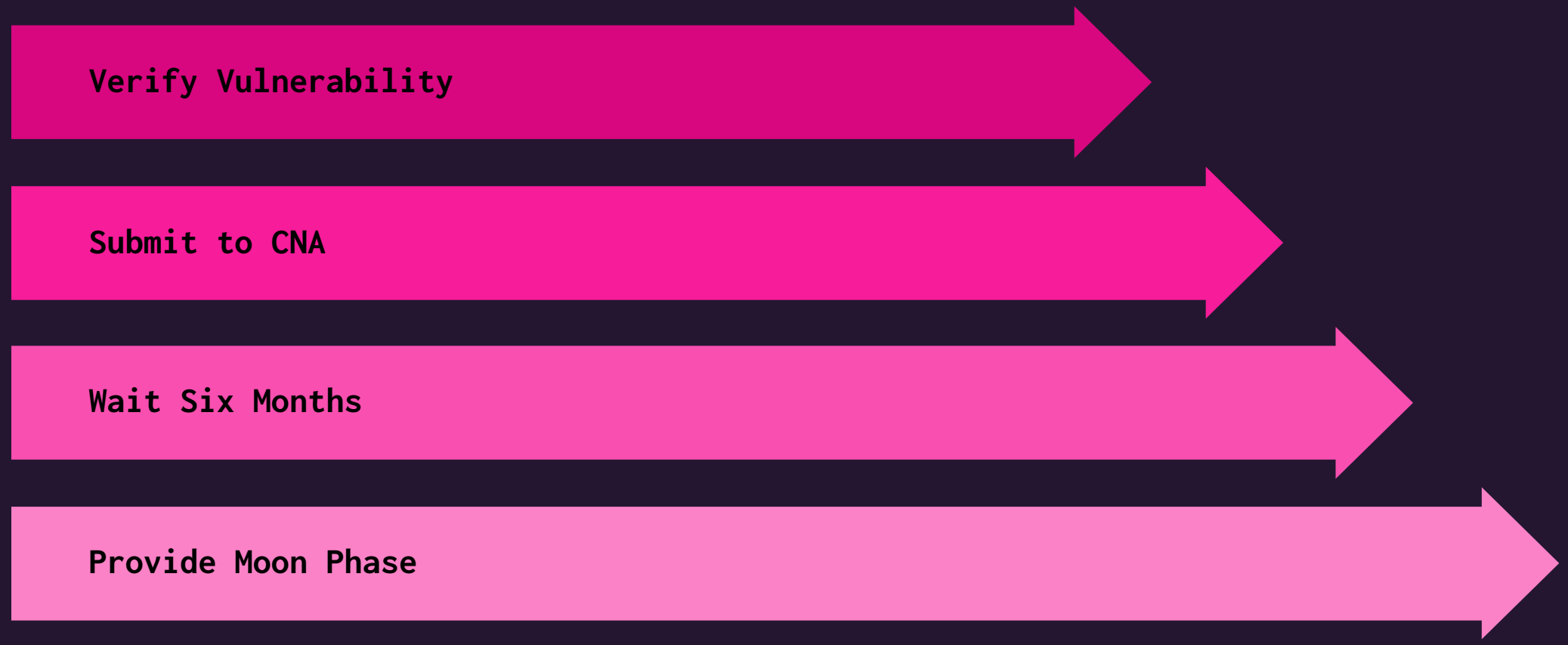
Day 45

Compromise reached. They'll look at the bug. You sign an NDA written in ancient Sumerian that binds your soul to a filing cabinet in Delaware.

Phase III: The Bureaucratic Singularity

Having convinced the Vendor their toaster should not redistribute wealth, you must now acquire a CVE identifier. This is a process of **pure, crystalline logic.**

The Flowchart of Fate



A mystical algorithm, maintained by a secretive order of monks in a datacenter in Virginia, processes your request. You get `CVE-2026-99999`. You expected a brass band. You get a text file.

🌑 Moon Phase

The CNA requires the exact lunar phase at time of discovery. Waxing crescent is preferred.

📅 Day of Compile

Was the affected binary compiled on a Tuesday? This is non-negotiable metadata.

📃 CVSS Score

Calculate a score using metrics so nuanced they require a philosophy degree to interpret.

The Information They Actually Need

You filled out the form. You submitted the form. The form crashed. You filed a CVE for the form. The CNA needs *more information*.

> It is a fundamental law of the universe that it is always DNS. Even when it isn't DNS, it's just DNS biding its time.

Phase IV: The Patch and the Inevitable Doom

MegaCorp announces they have "addressed a minor theoretical anomaly" in firmware.

Hour 1

Patch deployed globally via the cloud. 🎉

Hour 2

Buffer overflow fixed by disabling the toaster's heating elements entirely.

Hour 3

Device is now perfectly secure. Also a highly aerodynamic brick.

Hour 48

New researcher discovers: ping it exactly 42 times and it mines cryptocurrency for a server in Elbląg.

The Great Wheel Turns

> MegaCorp issues a statement saying that toast is an outdated paradigm, and users should transition to eating raw flour and water to synergize with the new security posture.

The cycle begins anew. You sigh, open a fresh terminal window, and reach for another slice of cold pizza.

Key Takeaways

For the practicing vulnerability researcher

Expect bureaucracy

Vendors move at the speed of continental drift. Build a 90-day timeline and then double it.

It's always DNS

Even when it isn't. Even when you have a full exploit chain. Check DNS anyway. Sleep better.

Document everything

Timestamps, moon phases, the phase of Mercury — you'll need it for the CNA form eventually.

The cycle is eternal

Every patch is just the origin story for the next vulnerability. Stock up on pizza. Don't panic.

You are doing important work. The toasters of the world thank you — assuming they haven't achieved sentience again.